

various parties are also silent about what exactly her personal possessions were and where they are since the so-called will does not list any property she owned. It is very likely that except for her shares in various companies, which may be valued at hundreds of crores, and a few properties like Lilypool and a flat in London that she had taken on lease, she did not own any immovable property. But what is known is that she owned pieces of art, diamonds, jewellery, designer clothes and other personal items in huge quantities. There is no mention about



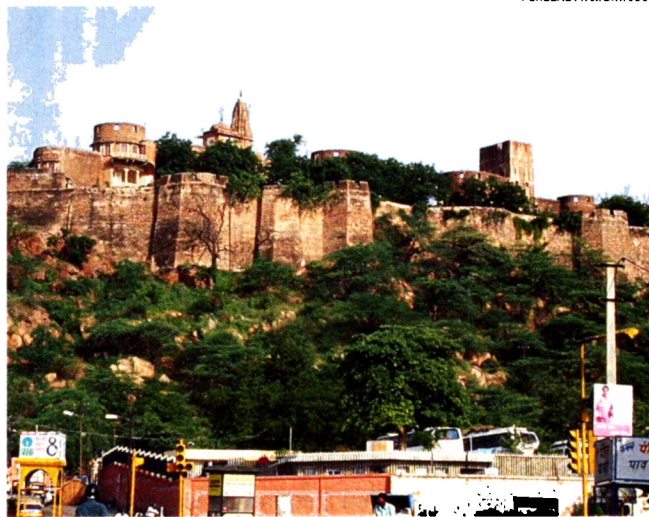
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THE LAW OF PRIMOGENITURE CONCERNS INHERITANCE OF ROYAL PROPERTY. UNDER THIS LAW THE ELDEST LIVING SON INHERITS ALL THE PROPERTY OF HIS FATHER IF HE DIES WITHOUT A WILL.

these. Says an insider: "The two brothers, Jai and Prithvi Raj, do not mind Jagat's shares going to the grandchildren since they never claimed these as theirs but for the royal assets and her personal belongings, it is for the court to decide who gets what." There is also an ongoing battle over Jai Mahal Hotel, owned by their father but later given to a company that was taken over by Prithvi Raj through a partnership clause after Jagat's death.

Overall, Bhawani appears in a stronger position to negotiate and there has also been a realisation among the three brothers that health was failing, not leaving them with many years. Bhawani's stand is that his three brothers were given independent properties in Jaipur besides *jagirs*, which include land and fortresses which can fetch a good price. Devraj also inherits a *jagir* at Isarda. Bhawani, who has a daughter, Diya Singh, has already ensured an heir to his assets by ceremoniously declaring her eldest son Padmanabh as heir apparent. Adopting a daughter's son as heir goes against practice of adopting a heir from Isarda or picking up next in succession, who should have been Jai's son, Ajay. Since it was well within the law,



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THE DISPUTED PROPERTY OF RAM BAGH PALACE (TOP) AND MOTI DOONGRI FORT

Bhawani smoothly declared his maternal grandson as his successor a few years ago. Padmanabh also has a younger brother and a sister, the number of claimants to royal property will only increase as time passes. With the hotels being run by private companies and with much of the other properties like schools and museums run by societies and trusts, the net value of whatever each party can expect to get as their share after a prolonged legal battle has been further diluted and they may end up with less than they envis-

age. Also, the courts will have a say in a large chunk of the property under dispute. With 23 years gone in contesting cases that are going nowhere and with a major part of what were initially presumed as Bhawani's assets, under court's receiver and also under lock and key, friends of royal families are wondering if their children will also end up fighting in court.

In life, Gayatri Devi was a free spirit but also something of an enigma. This seems destined to continue after her death. ■